



Bhanu Prakash Srivastava's guru mantras

- The only results you should be concerned about are the results for the organisation, not for your individual self!
- Times will come when teams need to make sacrifices. Be the first one to be ready to sacrifice for the team!
- Running after designations is like chasing a wild goose. Chase efficiency if you want to chase something!
- Stay relevant by constantly updating yourself with the latest from your industry and how it intersects with everything else. It is easy for others to fool you if you do not stay relevant!
- Everything you expect from your team, you should be able to give them!
- Do not be afraid to upset people if that is the requirement of the task at hand. Similarly, always be ready to get upset by people!
- The applause for the success of a project belongs to the team, never to an individual!

the top 50. As he was not getting the engineering branch of his choice in IITs, the option was choosing between IT BHU and the University of Roorkee. He could get any branch of his choice in these two institutes. He chose IT BHU—the reason being ₹750 difference in fee structure! BHU (Banaras Hindu University's engineering colleges were a part of IIT entrance exams back in those days. Not only was Srivastava getting an admission in a good college, he was also getting the mechanical engineering stream, and on top of everything the fee for BHU was almost ₹750 less than that of Roorkee.

"BHU's fee was ₹359. A train ticket to my hometown from BHU college was much cheaper than a train ticket to Roorkee. Money was so scarce a resource for us those days that I had to choose between the entrance exams I wanted to give as every exam form needed a fee," he shares.

He adds, "I was happy choosing BHU as I knew I could visit my family more than I could have visited while studying at IIT Roorkee. One more reason that triggered Srivastava's decision to join BHU was his visit to the same in his childhood with his elder brother. The latter was studying in BHU when he had taken his younger brother to see and feel the experience of studying in one of

the most sought after colleges and institutions in India."

India over the US, engineering over civil services

The first semester at BHU did not come easy at all for Srivastava. Though he ranked 14th in the first set of results, it was a shock for a student who was always in the merit lists! Srivastava could not believe the results he had yielded despite studying hard, and instead of going into a state of denial, he chose to find out the reason. BHU was filled with toppers from all over India: the competition, as he recalls, was tough, but he had not left any stone unturned. Then what was the cause of him being able to secure only 14th rank?

"English was the main problem. Though I was a topper in the subject at school level, the English everyone spoke at the BHU campus was completely different from the English we learned at school level. All lectures used to be in English, the study material used to be in English, and most discussions would be in English," Srivastava says.

Everyone at BHU was busy studying, and Srivastava could not find help for learning English. He started listening to BBC news shows on the radio to build mastery over

the language. In the next semester result Srivastava got first rank. From then on, he was in the top three ranks most of the time.

Listening to BBC shows also sparked his curiosity about global affairs and India's place in the world. As a result, he started comparing India's growth to that of the modern world.

"This was the point when I made up my mind to work for the country till the last breath. Though a lot of my fellow students were going to the United States and other parts of the world, I wanted to stay here in India and serve my country. In the form of scholarships, the country had spent so much on me. It was my time to dedicate myself to the country," he says with a proud face. Srivastava did not have a passport till he joined BEL and was sent to Tokyo for training in 1989.

Even though Srivastava had a great inclination towards the coveted civil services exam of India, he decided not to pursue it because he believed every effort made by him for gaining technical knowledge and every penny spent by the government of the country in enabling the same "would go in vain."

"I sometimes think I could have helped a lot in policymaking if I had chosen to give the civil services exam. However, I am happy that because of BEL, I have been able to work with a lot of departments of the government," he says.

Srivastava was selected at BEL via campus interviews and was holding multiple job offers when he appeared for the BEL interview. In fact, many companies reached out to him while he was working with BEL, with job offers that promised much higher salaries. He says he has never considered such an offer.

Ringin a bell at BEL

Before joining BEL, Srivastava was asked about his choice of posting.